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8 Keys to Transforming a City's Mobility Infrastructure

Making communities more walkable and bike-friendly requires dedicated resources and political capital.

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In this excerpt from “[Urban Bikeway Design Guide, Third Edition](#)” by the National Association of City Transportation Officials (NACTO), the organization writes about the leadership required to achieve transformative change on city streets and in transportation networks. It is published here with permission from Island Press.

Today's top city leaders recognize the key role that transportation plays in solving current climate, economic, safety, equity, and health challenges.

But true leadership requires more than just a recognition of the importance of transportation. It requires setting a vision, dedicating resources, laying the groundwork for success, and committing political capital, so that when the work gets tough, projects still get done and a city's transportation network reaches its full potential.

An impactful leader starts by articulating a broad vision for city transportation: where streets are safe, transit connects people to their destinations, and biking is accessible to people of all ages, abilities, and backgrounds. In this city, residents can walk out their door, hop on a bike or scooter, ride on safe, well-designed streets, connect to transit, and arrive at their appointments on time and without worry.

To be effective, this vision is codified and repeatedly underscored — in speeches, interviews, policy-setting documents, and in meetings with elected officials, with residents, and, importantly, with the staff entrusted to make their city a great place to walk and bike.

For this vision to be successful, leaders must pave the way not just with broadly stated support but with real resources, structures, and backing when progress gets tough.

For transformative change on city streets and in transportation networks, leaders must provide:

1. An Articulation Of What A Transformative Bike Network Looks Like

A transformative bike network requires high-quality bike infrastructure that is comfortable and inviting for riders of all ages and abilities, designed as part of a connected network, and built equitably so that the neighborhoods that would most benefit from safer, more inviting streets are prioritized.

2. An Organizational Structure That Supports The Delivery Of High-Quality Bike Projects

When city agencies are strategically and intentionally organized, with strong coordination and clear hand-offs, they are more likely to deliver projects on time and on budget, scale outputs to meet needs and solve issues early and quickly.

3. Clearly Outlined Policies, Priorities, And Commitments To Biking

Outlining coherent goals (such as 50% of residents living within a three-minute walk of a high-quality bike facility), priorities (safe travel instead of more on-street parking), and policies (e-bike purchase subsidies, reformed traffic laws) can connect an inspiring vision to tangible change on the ground. These policies and priorities also connect biking to other city goals—such as extending the reach of transit, making streets safer for everyone, increasing access to jobs, and reducing greenhouse gas emissions.

4. Reliable And Sufficient Funding To Accomplish Priority Projects And Policies

When agency staff can count on a predictable funding stream, they can efficiently match the resources available instead of chasing one-off projects. Sufficient and reliable funding is key for staff to move from scrambling to thoughtfully engaging all units of city government, contractors, and residents in predictable, carefully planned, year-over-year improvements to city streets.

5. An Investment In Staff

Dedicated leaders invest in their staff. They advocate for new positions to meet the city's goals and hire using equitable practices. They support and champion their workforce, from office staff to field staff. They help managers create and use clear, transparent, and accessible processes to deliver projects and develop an inclusive, supportive working environment.

6. Resources For Community Engagement And Communication.

Robust staffing and support for community engagement practices that match neighborhood needs are essential. Agency staff need resources to work alongside residents, helping them understand how they can shape their streets and how citywide priorities can be applied to transportation projects like building transformative bike networks.

7. Clear Decision-Making Processes

Clarifying and publishing decision-making processes helps agency staff and community members build alignment, trust, and a shared understanding of how to effectively collaborate and reduces the risk of individual voices canceling or diminishing safety-forward street projects.

8. A Willingness To Pivot And Rapidly Respond

Pushback is part of the process of making change. Effective leaders listen with openness to community concerns, work to understand the bigger picture and act nimbly to address concerns and show progress.

Upgrading streets that have not meaningfully changed in decades is hard and requires real leadership. Residents must be able to tangibly see the positive impacts of safer streets and inviting places to ride—and until then, leaders must commit to working through a process of communication and patience that can be difficult and complicated.

With committed leadership, the end result can be transformative. By building high-quality bike networks—and therefore safer, more equitable, and inviting streets—leaders can connect their residents to opportunity and to each other. Investing boldly, thoughtfully, and comprehensively will enable city leaders to make streets safer, unlock opportunities for their residents, and make their cities healthier and more joyful.

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